

Getting to Grips Version 2

2026 update to the mandatory guidance on Relationships Education, Relationships & Sex Education and Health Education

Some key advice for Wandsworth, Kingston
and Richmond schools

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Statement of Support from DCS and Children's Councillors

insert here the joint contribution / statement by the Directors of Children's Services of the three
Local Authorities

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Section 1 – The updated guidance – a brief overview

‘Children and young people need knowledge and skills that will enable them to make informed and ethical decisions about their well-being, health and relationships. High quality, evidence-based teaching of relationships, sex and health education (RSHE) can help prepare pupils for the opportunities and responsibilities of adult life, and can promote their moral, social, mental and physical development. Effective teaching will support young people to cultivate positive characteristics including resilience, self-worth, self-respect, honesty, integrity, courage, kindness and trustworthiness. Effective teaching will support prevention of harms by helping young people understand and identify when things are not right.’

DfE Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education (RSE) and Health Education Statutory guidance for governing bodies, proprietors, head teachers, principals, senior leadership teams and teachers July 2025 page 2

Schools have long been expected to deliver education that prepares children to take their place in the adult world. This has previously included learning about how their bodies work, how to be healthy and stay safe, both in the real world and the virtual, and how to get on with others in a positive and friendly way. Since the Equalities Act of 2010, schools have also been required to follow this legislation in ensuring that the education they provide incorporates and promotes the inclusion of all aspects of society, with reference to specific protected characteristics such as race, religion/belief, age, sex, gender reassignment, marital/partnership status, sexuality and ability. This education should be balanced, value-free and impartial.

In 2020, the DfE published new, statutory guidance on Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education and Health Education, and it now has updated this guidance to reflect changes in the law, and new issues that have become more prominent for young people since the publication of the original guidance seven years ago. Relationships, Sex and Health Education (RSHE) will continue to be inspected by Ofsted as part of the basic curriculum, and the impact of this learning will continue to be part of a school’s judgement in regards to inspectors’ consideration of pupils’ personal development, behaviour and welfare, and spiritual, moral and cultural development.

The 2026 updated guidance for RSHE is extended to Multi Academy Trust central staff teams, management committees of PRU’s and providers of alternative provision including AP academies and AP free schools, where specific thought should be given to the particular needs and vulnerabilities of the pupils and what adjustments might be needed.

Schools are expected to review their existing policies and curricula for RSHE for implementation from September 2026, to ensure that their curriculum is informed by meaningful engagement with pupils and that it is relevant, engaging, and age and stage appropriate, with sequenced teaching so that pupils are supported and equipped with the knowledge to navigate different experiences in a positive way before they occur, and to prevent possible harms. Parents and carers still play a part in a school’s review processes, continuing the good practice already established by which schools explain their curriculum. Part of the review process for the school’s RSHE policy and curriculum should include consultation with parents. Further, it is now mandatory that schools should be transparent with parents and carers about the materials used in the teaching of RSHE, which should be made available to them.

Schools should also take active steps to engage pupils in designing what is taught.

Dealing with the topics which are covered by the updated guidance will require skilled delivery either by school staff or external providers, in order to create the safe and supportive environment needed to facilitate participative and interactive education, which aims to support rather than alarm pupils. From early 2026, schools will be able to apply for training grants to help their staff tackle these challenges with confidence. Safeguarding training continues to be important, in the event of disclosures made during or outside of lessons.

The updated RSHE guidance continues to empower schools by requiring delivery of a mandatory curriculum, and puts a renewed focus on positivity – emphasising the building of skills and positive attitudes amongst pupils, promoting healthy norms about relationships, including sexual relationships where relevant, and health, including mental health. The programmes of study for both primary and secondary phases are covered in detail in the updated guidance on pages 8 to 32 and these form a useful guide and a basis for both an audit of the school's curriculum, and a review of the policy.

Some headline developments to note from the new guidance are -

Principles, structure & flexibility The new guidance emphasises pupil engagement, transparency with parents, and emphasises positivity and relevance as guiding principles. Schools will need show how they take active steps to engage their pupils in designing a curriculum that is relevant to student's lives, engages them in learning it and is transparent with parents about the materials used to deliver it.

Age and stage The new guidance emphasises sequencing and building up knowledge and skills progressively, rather than prescribing age limits. There is also an acknowledgement that some issues may be more prominent or pressing in some areas, or for individual or groups of children, which may require schools to consider when it is best to teach them. This gives schools more discretion in how and when to introduce topics, but also increases the responsibility to justify the sequencing choices they make.

LGBTQ+ The new guidance more strongly encourages primary schools to include same-sex parents when discussing families, and in secondary to integrate healthy same-sex relationships into discussions throughout, rather than limit incorporating LGBTQ+ issues to one specific topic area, taught only once.

Gender Identity The new guidance states schools "should be careful not to endorse any particular view or teach it as fact," acknowledging there is debate over gender identity. The law should be the base for discussing these, and other issues, with a clear emphasis that respect for protected characteristics remains enshrined in that law.

New or expanded content Content is now added on some specific areas which reflect the evolving social, online, and safety challenges that were less prominent (or less clearly addressed) back in 2019. The online world has become a much more 'real' space for children and young people and helping them to understand what is 'real' and 'not real' has become significantly more important. Schools have a mandate to tackle these issues but may need to help teachers develop the skills and resources to cover these issues sensitively and effectively. Issues include :

- Misogyny, sexual harassment, sexual violence (public sexual harassment, revenge porn, upskirting, financial sexual exploitation, sexual strangulation/suffocation)
- Online harms & digital literacy around deepfakes, AI-generated sexual imagery, sharing images online, privacy, scams, and manipulation of images

- Personal safety, recognising and assessing risk, managing change & loss (including bereavement)
- Mental health, coping skills, resilience, suicide prevention
- Positive masculinity, ethical behaviour, challenging stereotypes / sexism

Emphasis on skills The new guidance gives stronger emphasis to skills development such as communication, assertiveness, boundary setting, resisting pressures, resilience, alongside factual knowledge. Dynamic learning using practical exercises, discussion, role play or scenario work may need to be introduced, or strengthened, to work towards this.

Parental engagement & transparency The new guidance strengthens the expectations that schools must consult parents when developing or renewing their curriculum and RSE/RSHE policy. Parents cannot veto content, and the right to withdraw their children from 'sex education' remains, although not the areas where the Science or Health curriculum are relevant. This remains unchanged, however schools should allow parents/carers to be able to view all curriculum materials used, responding positively to these requests. A section of the new guidance informs schools about the limits of contractual and copyright issues in this area, as these should not form a barrier to sharing materials used, including using those from third party providers. This new requirement may, at least at first, increase parental requests to see materials and schools should consider how best to share materials and explain curriculum choices.

Some Considerations & Challenges

Navigating controversy and balance: Topics like gender identity, transgender issues, and LGBTQ+ content are more explicitly addressed in the new guidance. In teaching this, schools should be mindful that, beyond the facts and the law about biological sex and gender reassignment there is significant debate, and they should be careful not to endorse any particular view or teach it as fact. Good staff training and a clear knowledge of the law will be fundamental to doing this effectively. Without adequate teacher training, there is a risk of poor implementation.

Resource development & updating schemes: The new guidance updates that given in 2019, requiring schools to audit the provision and materials they already have, and working out which areas need development to align with new expectations. A review of the RSHE policy will also be necessary in regard of the new guidance, and engagement with both pupils and parents needs to be considered as part of this. With the stronger requirements on transparency and parent consultation, schools may face more scrutiny from parents over content, and so taking a lead on the narrative regarding the school's policy and curriculum would help integrate any new areas and make parents more confident of what the school curriculum is, what resources are being used and how the lessons are being delivered. Parents/carers trust schools to deliver curriculum content in other areas and this should be emphasised as no different.

Sequencing & adaptation across phases: Because the new guidance avoids rigid age cut-offs, schools must plan progression carefully to make sure content is covered at the right time for pupils to be aware of issues that may present harm to them. Thought should be given so as to avoid introducing content too soon or too late.

Monitoring, evaluation, and review: Schools will need to look at their mechanisms which evaluate how well the new curriculum is working and gather feedback from teachers, pupils and parents/carers, and use this to make appropriate adjustments if these are deemed necessary.

Feeding back to all stakeholders when this is done will also form part of a transparent approach to delivering the curriculum.

Section 2 Specific points to note (page numbers refer to the updated RSHE guidance July 2025)

It is recommended that school leaders read the updated guidance in its entirety, but below are some specific points regarding some notable additions to the 2019 guidance.

Governors and Trustees (page 34)

The updated guidance stipulates that alongside their other legal obligations, Governing boards and proprietors of Academy trusts should also ensure that all pupils make progress in achieving the expected educational outcomes, that teaching is made accessible to those pupils with SEND, the curriculum content and materials are aligned with the statutory guidance contained in the new update, and that clear information is provided for parents/carers on the subject content, teaching materials, and external providers and on the right to request that their child is withdrawn from sex education.

Foundation governors of maintained schools and trustees of academy trusts that include schools with a designated religious character will also have wider responsibilities in relation to maintaining and developing the religious ethos of their faith schools.

Teaching about the Law (page 35)

The updated guidance says that there 'will be a range of opinion' regarding some topics covered in RSHE and a school's starting principle should be that the law should be taught in a factual way so that pupils are clear about their rights and responsibilities as citizens. A list of legal provisions relevant to the topics covered in RSHE is given and schools should be familiar with the laws which cover them, specifically :

- Marriage including forced marriage and civil partnerships
- Consent including the age of consent
- Domestic abuse, stalking, rape, sexual offences, FGM, 'virginity testing' and hymenoplasty
- Sexual Abuse, harassment and exploitation, including public sexual harassment and harmful sexual behaviour
- The Online Safety Act
- Online behaviours including image and information sharing (including sexual imagery, youth-produced sexual imagery, nudes etc and including AI generated sexual imagery and deepfakes)
- Online sexual harassment and online sexual abuse including grooming and sextortion.
- Pornography
- Abortion
- Protected characteristics
- Alcohol, smoking, vaping and nicotine products and illicit drug use
- Gambling
- Carrying knives and weapons
- Extremism/radicalisation
- Grooming or exploiting children into criminal activity which can include gang involvement and county lines drug running

- Hate crime
- The age of criminal responsibility
- Medical consent, Gillick competence and parental responsibility (this would also incorporate the Frasier guidance although it is not specifically mentioned in the new guidance)

Equality (page 36)

Schools are required to comply with the relevant requirements of the Equality Act (2010) including the Public Sector equality duty (PSED) when teaching RSHE, in order for the pupils to understand the importance of equality and respect and learn about the law relating to the protected characteristics of age, disability, gender reassignment, sexual orientation, marriage, civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief and sex.

Schools must also ensure that topics in RSHE are taught in a way which does not discriminate against pupils or amount to harassment, avoid language which repeats or enforces gender stereotypes, and to encourage young people to express their views while remaining respectful of others.

Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender (page 36)

Regarding Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender content, primary schools are encouraged to teach about healthy, loving relationships and to include same-sex parents along with other family arrangements when discussing families. Secondary schools are advised that there should be an equal opportunity to explore the features of stable and healthy same-sex relationships and this should be integrated throughout a programme of study rather than form the focus of a stand-alone unit. The requirement to cover the diverse range and nature of family life and relationships also continues to fall into the category of Relationships Education, and as such the Right to Withdraw does not apply to it. Should a parent/carer insist that this is not the case, headteachers should contact Wandsworth/Kingston/Richmond Local Authority for further guidance (please see section 8 of this document for relevant contact details)- we will put the appropriate list of personnel and contact details in nearer publication date.

Biological Sex and Gender Reassignment (page 36)

Regarding issues of biological sex and gender reassignment, pupils should be taught the facts and the law around these issues, and be mindful that as there is significant debate about these issues, schools should be careful not to endorse any particular view nor teach it as fact. This includes the recognition that people have legal rights by virtue of their biological sex which are different from the rights of those of the opposite sex with the protected characteristic of gender reassignment, and that all people with protected characteristics have protection from discrimination and should be treated with respect and dignity.

Regarding the use of external resources to teach these issues, schools are told to avoid the use of materials using cartoons or diagrams that may over-simplify this topic, or that may perpetuate stereotypes or encourage pupils to question their gender.

Religion and belief, including teaching in schools with a religious character (page 37)

RSHE should be sensitive to the religious backgrounds of pupils, and schools should comply with the provisions of the Equality Act 2010 under which religion and belief are amongst the protected characteristics. All schools may teach about faith perspectives on the topics covered and schools with a particular religious character may teach their distinctive faith perspective on relationships,

and balanced debate may take place about issues that are contentious. Schools should be clear when they are delivering content that reflects religious belief.

Pupils with SEND (page 37)

Teaching should be developed to ensure RSHE is accessible to pupils with SEND and prepare pupils for adulthood. Schools should be aware that SEND pupils may be more vulnerable than their peers to harmful sexual behaviour, sexual abuse, exploitation, violence, bullying and other issues, and so be aware that RSHE is particularly important for these students.

Addressing sexual harassment and sexual violence (page 38)

The updated guidance pays particular attention to the development of skills young people need to build healthy relationships and grow into kind, respectful adults. From early primary, schools are expected to support children to develop the skills necessary for positive, healthy relationships, including navigating boundaries with kindness and respect. These skills should be developed into secondary stage and will support pupils to understand and identify prejudice and to behave respectfully.

Regarding sexual violence, pupils should understand that anyone can be the victim of sexual violence, the victim is never to blame, and that most sexual violence is committed against women and girls, and often has a gendered component for example manifesting in an inequality of power between men and women, but language which stigmatises boys or suggests that boys and men are always perpetrators, or that women are always victims, should be avoided.

Staff should consider the language used in and beyond the classroom and take action to build a culture where prejudice is defined and tackled. Staff have an important role in modelling positive behaviour and avoiding language that might perpetuate harmful stereotypes. Pupils should understand the importance of challenging harmful beliefs and attitudes, and understand the link between sexism and misogyny and violence against women and girls. Where misogynistic ideas are expressed at school, staff should challenge the idea rather than the person expressing them.

Pupils should have opportunities to develop positive conceptions of masculinity, including how to identify and learn from positive masculine role models.

Safeguarding (page 39)

Discussion of sensitive topics can lead to increased safeguarding reports so schools should ensure that all staff know what to do if they have concerns that a pupil is being neglected or abused. Keeping Children Safe in Education guidance provides a strong safeguarding framework and is clear on the actions a school or college should take if there are any concerns around a pupil's safety. In addition, if external providers are being used to deliver any lessons, schools must agree in advance how a safeguarding concern would be dealt with by the external visitor should it arise.

The updated guidance also refers to plans for new legislation which will make it a legal requirement for anyone in a regulated activity in England, including teachers, to report if they are made aware a child is being sexually abused.

The updated guidance reminds schools that mandatory reporting of FGM still pertains and that virginity testing and hymenoplasty became illegal in 2022. Staff should report any concerns regarding a child's welfare following KCSIE guidelines, and their own school's Child Protection policy, and speak to the DSL.

Managing Difficult Questions (page 40)

The school's RSE policy should cover the eventuality of pupils asking questions about topics which go beyond any sex education covered by school or relating to sex education from which a pupil may have been withdrawn, explaining how a teacher would handle such questions with an emphasis on supporting the child. This may include asking the pupil to speak to a parent/carer, signposting to support services where needed and recognising that children whose questions go unanswered may turn to inappropriate sources for information, including online. The updated guidance recognises that this may be an area where staff may need training and support.

Regulations (page 41)

The Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education, and Health Education (England) Regulations 2019 are made under sections 34 and 35 of the Children and Social Work Act 2017 and still pertain. Pupils receiving primary education must be taught relationships education, pupils receiving secondary education must be taught RSE and all primary and secondary pupils must be taught health education. This applies to all maintained schools, academies, pupil referral units, maintained special schools, special academies and in maintained special schools. RSE must be taught in independent schools.

Schools must have regard to the guidance produced by the DfE, make a statement of policy on their provision of relationships education and RSE, and set out the circumstances in which a pupil is to be withdrawn from RSE.

These regulations now pertain to Multi Academy Trust central staff teams, management committees of PRU's and providers of alternative provision including AP academies and AP free schools.

Government Resources (page 42)

A list of clickable links to useful curriculum and wider resources can be found at the end of the updated guidance.

The new guidance and further relevant information can be found using these links

DfE Guidance on Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education (RSE) and Health Education – July 2025

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/68b8499e11b4ded2da19fd92/Relationships_education_on_relationships_and_sex_education_and_health_education_-_statutory_guidance.pdf

DfE Statutory Guidance Relationships Education (Primary) - updated

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/relationships-education-relationships-and-sex-education-rse-and-health-education/relationships-education-primary>

DfE Statutory Guidance Relationships Education (Secondary) - updated

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/relationships-education-relationships-and-sex-education-rse-and-health-education/relationships-and-sex-education-rse-secondary>

The Oak National Academy

<https://www.thenational.academy/teachers/search?term=%22our+online+lives%22&subjects=rse-pshe&contentType=unit&curriculum=new>

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Section 3 Parents and Carers

‘Schools should take steps to pro-actively engage parents and make sure they are aware of what is being taught in RSHE. These steps might include inviting parents into school to discuss the curriculum content and the importance of RSHE for wellbeing and safety, inviting them to discuss any concern, and supporting parents in managing conversations with their children about RSHE topics. Schools must consult parents when developing and reviewing their RSE policies in accordance with the section on developing a policy

DfE Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education (RSE) and Health Education Statutory Guidance July 2025 page 33

Parents and carers should be given opportunities to understand the purpose and content of the RSHE curriculum and to raise any questions or concerns they may have. They should understand that the subject is mandatory and will be carefully planned to be age-appropriate and developmental, and will prepare children and young people for life within and beyond school. In order to maintain the harmonious collaboration between schools and parents and carers, schools need to be proactive in engaging and informing them so that they understand what is being taught and that it is being taught in a balanced and impartial way. It is important for children to see that their family, however this is made up, is represented in their learning, so that they understand that families can be different but that they all have the same purpose – to love, care for and support the child.

A new requirement in the updated guidance is that schools should show parents a representative sample of the resources they plan to use, enabling parents to continue conversations started in class, and ensure that, if requested, parents/carers can view all curriculum materials used. Parents/carers are not able to veto curriculum content (page 34 of the new guidance) but schools must consult with them when developing their RSHE policy.

If a school uses external providers to deliver any aspect of the curriculum it is advised that schools should not agree to any contractual restrictions on showing parents any content that the school will use, as they are now legally obliged to have regard of the statutory guidance, and any such clauses that may now exist in contracts are now void and unenforceable, because they contradict the clear public policy interest of ensuring parents/carers are aware of what their children are being taught in sex and relationships education.

Where copyright law exists, schools are expected to comply with it, and the use of a ‘parent portal’ for viewing resources is advised as best practice, with the caveat that when schools make resources available, they should include a statement that parents/carers agree as a condition of access that content should not be copied or shared further in accordance with copyright law. IT restrictions such as to prevent any downloading could be used where possible, and the authorship of any materials should be acknowledged.

If parents/carers cannot use any of the online or school-based presentations, copies may be made to take home provided the parent/carer agrees to a similar statement that they will not copy or share the content except as authorised in copyright law. Copyright law affects the way in which the materials are shared but should not be used as a reason not to share them.

The right of withdrawal from Sex Education

Under the updated guidance, parents/carers continue to have the right to request that their child be withdrawn from some or all of sex education delivered as part of statutory RSHE. From three terms

before the pupil turns 16, it becomes the young person's choice to opt into these lessons even if a parent/carer has requested withdrawal. Should a Primary school wish to designate any of their curriculum as Sex Education this needs to be clearly defined and it is to these lessons that parents/carers may exercise the right to withdraw. Parents/carers do not have the right to withdraw pupils from relationships education or health education, nor can they be withdrawn from topics taught as part of the Science curriculum, including topics related to puberty and sexual reproduction. Primary schools will have faced the issues regarding the teaching of Sex Education before, and the updated guidance continues to confirm current practice.

Suggested protocol should a parent or carer ask to withdraw their child from specific parts of the curriculum

Note – if the request is verbal and made to the classroom teacher or assistant, the member of staff should request that the parent or carer put their request in writing to the headteacher.

1 Inform the chair of governors and local authority of the request to withdraw. They should both be updated as the matter progresses.

2 Headteacher to invite the parent or carer into school, by phone or letter, for a meeting to discuss their request.

3 The headteacher should lead the meeting, and contemporaneous notes should be taken. These should be written up into a record of the meeting for school files and reference, as they may be required at a later date.

4 During the meeting the following areas could be discussed

- what the curriculum actually entails, and whether it is classified as Relationships Education, Relationships & Sex Education or Health Education
- teaching materials should be shared and explained
- the statutory nature of the content should be explained
- the right to withdraw should be discussed, and the updated guidance applied to judge if the request is in accordance with it
- other parental feedback to the curriculum could be discussed if appropriate
- materials regarding faith responses could be used (see the 'Useful Links' in Section 7 of this document)
- the parent or carer could be given the opportunity to go away and consider their request and whether they wish it to go ahead

5 The meeting should be followed up as soon as possible by a letter to the parent / carer thanking them for attending the meeting, summarising the matters discussed and asking for the parent or carer's response within a reasonable timeframe. It could be included that if no response is received within the timeframe then it will be assumed that they have decided not to go ahead with their request.

6 Depending on the response the headteacher should write again to the parent or carer, explaining next steps – either that the pupil will attend all aspects for the lessons or how the withdrawal will be arranged. It would be worth pointing out what specifically the withdrawal refers to and what it does not e.g. it may not need to be for an entire lesson, and during the time of withdrawal that further, alternative work will be set for the pupil.

7 Should there be a further issue or complaint after this – contact Wandsworth/Richmond/Kingston Local Authority for advice and guidance.

Written communication with parents and carers

The following sample letters are intended as a suggested template only, as you will need to reflect your own specific practice and write a letter which best suits your school community and situation.

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Sample letter 1 Letter to parents and carers to introduce the topics for the year

Dear Parent/ Carer

Re: Relationships Education (and Relationships& Sex Education if applicable) and Health Education information session for parents and carers

As you will be aware, Relationships Education (and Relationships& Sex Education if applicable) and Health Education form an important part of the Personal Social Health and Economic (PSHE) education programme at (name of school). PSHE education is the curriculum subject that gives children the knowledge, understanding, attitudes and practical skills to live safe, healthy, productive lives and meet their full potential.

As you will know, today there is a large amount of information about relationships and puberty in the media which children encounter as they use the internet and watch television, which is not made for children or put into an appropriate context. This can sometimes make an already confusing time seem even more complicated.

If students are provided with information about their bodies and relationships that is developed specially for them and delivered from a source that can be trusted to be appropriate to their needs at the stage of development they are at, they can make their transition into adulthood with the knowledge to understand what is happening to them, and grow into confident and healthy adults able to make positive choices. School is best placed to provide this information in the right way, and it is now compulsory that schools do this for their pupils.

Relationships Education (and Relationships& Sex Education if applicable) and Health Education is also essential in supporting schools to meet their safeguarding duty of care for all pupils. This year, classroom teachers will be using a wide range of child-friendly, age-appropriate resources to deliver these topics in the most suitable way for our children.

We will be running an information session for parents and carers about this topic on (date) at (time) in (venue).

During this session we will explain the kind of topics covered, how the lessons will be structured and give a chance for parents and carers to view the teaching materials we will be using. As part of the evening we will also discuss how you can best support your child when discussing these topics at home.

(Also consider adding, if this is the case - As a school community we are committed to working in partnership with parents and carers, and recent parental feedback has indicated that the overwhelming majority of parents continue to be impressed by and supportive of the RSHE teaching at our school.)

Yours sincerely,

Headteacher

Pupil name _____ Class _____

I am / am not able to attend the Relationships Education and Health Education information session on (date)

Signed _____ Parent / Carer Print name _____

Sample letter 2 Response to letter requesting withdrawal from any part of the school Relationships Education, (and Relationships and Sex Education if applicable) and/or Health Education curriculum

Dear Parent / Carer

Thank you for writing to me to express your request to withdraw your son/daughter/ward from lessons relating to the statutory curriculum for Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education and Health Education.

In order to discuss your request, please contact (name/role) to arrange to come in and meet with me in person so that we can discuss your concerns in more detail and I can take you through the topics about which you are concerned, show you the materials we use in class and explain your rights more fully to you.

I look forward to meeting with you on this matter.

Yours sincerely,

Headteacher

Sample letter 3 Letter expressing regret that parents or carers wish to exercise their right to withdraw from Sex Education as taught by schools and defining what this right to withdraw will refer to in specific lessons.

Dear Parent / Carer

It is with regret that I write to acknowledge your formal request for (name of student) to be withdrawn from aspects of the Relationships and Sex Education curriculum. The areas of this topic for which you have the right to request this withdrawal are :

(list specific topics)

As we discussed in our meeting, all other aspects of the curriculum are statutory and the right to withdraw does not apply to them.

During lessons when the above topics are taught (name of pupil) will go to (area of school) where they will be supervised. Please note this may be for either a whole or only part of a particular lesson. During this time they will be set alternative work which they will complete.

Yours sincerely,

Headteacher

Sample letter 4 Letter explaining that the Right to Withdraw does not apply to the topics requested by the parent / carer

Dear Parent / Carer

I am writing to follow up our meeting on the (date) at which we discussed your request to exercise the Right to Withdraw your child (name) from some lessons within our RSHE curriculum, namely (insert relevant details here).

As we discussed, these topics are covered under the (Relationships Education / Health Education / National Curriculum for Science) and the Right to Withdraw pupils from these lessons does not apply to them. Consequently (name) will study these topics along with his/her classmates, in accordance with government guidance on this matter.

Yours sincerely,

Headteacher

Sample letter 5 – Sharing Resources

Dear Parent / Carer

I am writing to acknowledge your request to view the resources that the school uses to teach RSHE. In order to do this please go to our parent portal on the school's website, where you will find a representative sample of the resources that are used in class. These resources are used to inform pupils about the topics required by the Department for Education in the statutory guidance regarding these subjects, and pupils are expected to show respect and consideration for others during any discussion on the lesson's topic.

Should you wish to see any resources for any particular aspect of the curriculum that is not represented on the website please let me know and I will arrange for you to be able to view them. Please note that in viewing these resources you are agreeing as a condition of access that the content may not be copied or shared further, in accordance with copyright law.

Yours sincerely,

Headteacher

Useful links for further guidance and information

DfE Guidance on Engaging parents with Relationships education **this has not been updated**

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/engaging-parents-with-relationships-education-policy>

PSHE Association Guide for Supporting Families **not yet updated**

<https://www.pshe-association.org.uk/curriculum-and-resources/resources/relationships-education-and-rse-guides-supporting>

Section 4 Some Policy Advice

Specific advice on developing a policy for RSE can be found in the 'Developing a Policy' section of the updated guidance (pages 4-5). Schools are not required to publish a policy for health education although it is recommended as good practice that schools should set out some of the details about how health education will be taught.

According to the updated guidance an RSE policy should –

- Set out the subject content, how and when it will be taught and who is responsible for teaching it, including any external providers the school will use
- Differentiate between relationships and sex education (where sex education is taught) so that parents have clear information. Relationships education does not involve explaining the detail of different forms of sexual activity, but can cover sensitive topics such as sexual violence, in order to keep children safe.
- Include information about a parent/carer's right to request their child is withdrawn from sex education
- Explain how the content will be made accessible to all pupils including those with SEND
- Describe how the subject is monitored and evaluated
- Set out how parents can view curriculum materials
- Explain how teachers will answer questions in sex education that the school does not cover (in primary) or that relates to sex education from which the child has been withdrawn
- Explain how the policy has been produced and how and when it will be reviewed.

A whole-school approach to well-being and positive relationships is advised by the updated guidance as a means to best deliver the curriculum. Consequently, schools may wish to continue to cross reference RSHE to other policies within the school as appropriate. Such policies might include :

- Safeguarding / Child Protection policy
- E-safety / acceptable use policy
- Equalities policy
- Behaviour policy
- British values policy
- SEND policy
- Citizenship policy
- Science policy
- Physical health and mental wellbeing policy
- Any other relevant policy within the school

Section 5 – OFSTED requirements

Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education and Health education

‘are part of the basic school curriculum. Which allows schools flexibility in developing their planned programme, integrated within a broad and balanced curriculum. Key aspects of RSHE are in scope for OFSTED inspection for example through inspectors’ consideration of pupils personal development, behaviour and welfare, and spiritual, moral, social and cultural development’ are part of the basic school curriculum.

‘DfE Guidance on RSE – July 2025 page 2 section 3

There is no specific ‘grade’ for Relationships Education, Relationships & Sex Education and Health Education but the teaching of it and the impact this makes on pupils’ learning will be looked at and form part of the judgements as above.

As always, OFSTED will be looking to see the impact of any teaching in these areas and thought should be given within a school as how to evidence this e.g. pre- and post-topic pupil skills audit or statistics regarding the reporting of and dealing with e.g. homophobic bullying, and the impact lessons may have made on reducing these.

It is important for schools to consider that the subject is taught by qualified, teaching staff trained in the delivery of the curriculum, and that any lessons should be thoroughly planned, prepared, resourced and evaluated. This can be evidenced by schemes of work, examples of student work / responses and teacher marking/comments/evaluations. It should have a designated subject lead who should be a member of the teaching staff and this post should be a ‘lead’ rather than a ‘co-ordinator’.

As with other areas of the curriculum, Relationships Education, Relationships & Sex Education and Health Education will require a statement of curriculum intent, and the learning map should indicate a clear sequencing of the topics studied, revisited at age-appropriate intervals. Schools should be able to demonstrate how they have engaged pupils in their development of the curriculum.

Budgeting for these subjects should allow for sufficient resourcing and staff training to deliver the curriculum effectively.

Useful links for further guidance and information

Education Inspection Framework for use from November 2025 – page 44

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/education-inspection-framework/education-inspection-framework-for-use-from-november-2025>

Inspection Toolkits

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/68b9a6b8b0a373a01819fe4b/Schools_inspection_toolkit.pdf

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/renewed-education-inspection-framework-supporting-evidence-base/education-inspection-toolkits-statutory-and-non-statutory-guidance-professional-standards-and-relevant-research>

Section 6 – Multi-faith responses

There may be some concerns raised regarding the statutory guidance on Relationships Education, Relationships & Sex Education and Health Education in schools following the updated guidance.

Wandsworth Local Authority has liaised with the Wandsworth Standing Advisory Council on Religious Education (SACRE) and the Wandsworth Multi-Faith group who have discussed the new guidance and have given support to its implementation and delivery in our schools. – this needs checking and Kingston and Richmond arrangements included

It would be helpful here to know what Wandsworth / Kingston / Richmond SACREs are doing – does anyone have any contacts for these ?

However, some parents and carers may not fully understand what Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education or Health Education cover and may express concerns with reference to their own personal faith backgrounds.

Responses by faith bodies and resources used in faith-based schools may be useful when dealing with concerns from parents and carers regarding issues to do with religion. Here are some links to resources created and used with the express agreement of designated faith organisations you may find useful.

Church of England

<https://www.churchofengland.org/about/education-and-schools/church-schools-and-academies/relationships-sex-and-health-education>

Roman Catholic – Ten Ten

<https://www.tentenresources.co.uk>

Islam – Association of Muslim Schools

<https://ams-uk.org/rse-hub/>

Judaism - Streetwise

<https://www.streetwisegb.org/rse>

RE online

<https://www.reonline.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2022/03/DfE-RSHE-framework-with-teachings-from-Jewish-Christian-and-Muslim-people-from-SECONDARY-schools.pdf>

Section 7 – Health Education

Whilst the new guidance from the DfE is focused on relationships and sex education, it acknowledges the great deal of overlap between the topics designated as RSE and those covered in the government guidance on Physical Health and Mental Well-being, which tasks schools to give pupils the information that they need to make good decisions about their own health and wellbeing, enabling them to develop the skills they need to make positive choices, recognise when issues arise and know how to seek support as early as possible from appropriate sources. Resilience is one such skill, which can help pupils to become confident in their ability to achieve well and persevere even when they encounter setbacks or when their goals are distant, and to respond calmly and rationally to setbacks and challenges.

As with RSE, schools have the flexibility to design and plan age-appropriate subject content, but government guidance sets out core areas for health and wellbeing that are appropriate for primary and secondary aged pupils. Topics for Health Education are set out clearly in the government guidance on Physical Health and Mental Wellbeing, and there are clear areas of overlap with RSE, and so these subjects are often taught in an integrated way as RSHE.

Topics which fall specifically within the remit of Health Education include –

- Puberty / menstruation / the changing adolescent body
- Physical Health and Mental Wellbeing
- The benefits of exercise, healthy eating and good nutrition, sufficient sleep
- Developing the knowledge and language of emotions, feelings and the development of their bodies
- Hygiene and self-care
- Sexual health, sexually transmitted diseases, HIV prevention
- The benefits of hobbies, interests and participation in community/social activity
- The difficulties and problems caused by isolation, bullying (including cyber bullying)
- Basic first aid and calling appropriate emergency services
- Healthy online habits, including discerning internet searching and possible internet harms and dangers
- Harms posed by drugs, alcohol, tobacco and obesity
- Facts around dental health, sun damage, allergies, immunisation, vaccination

Health Education shares RSE's emphasis on the importance of enabling pupils to make well-informed, positive choices for themselves.

The Government advice for Health Education can be found here-

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/relationships-education-relationships-and-sex-education-rse-and-health-education/physical-health-and-mental-wellbeing-primary-and-secondary>

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Section 8 - Local Authority Key Contacts / reporting requests to exercise the right to withdraw

Wandsworth, Kingston and Richmond Local Authorities are keen to support schools in their implementation and delivery of Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education and Health Education in accordance with statutory guidance.

Should schools receive requests to exercise the right to withdraw students, or experience targeting through pre-prepared letters requesting withdrawal, the Local Authority would like to be informed of these, and support where they can.

This is a list of personnel and departments to contact should there be an issue raised at your school.

Please can colleagues identify who these people or departments are and give us the correct contact information?

Department	Key Personnel	Contact details

Section 9 – Useful links

General

NEU

<https://neu.org.uk/advice/classroom/relationships-sex-and-health-education-rshe>

Sex Education Forum

<https://www.sexeducationforum.org.uk>

PSHE association

<https://pshe-association.org.uk/search?queryTerm=RSHE>

Stonewall

<https://www.stonewall.org.uk/resources/best-practice-toolkits-resources>

1 Decision

<https://www.1decision.co.uk>

Brook Learn

<https://learn.brook.org.uk/mod/page/view.php?id=2489>

Heartsmart TV

<https://www.heartsmarttv.com/carousel/videos/trailer-new-april-2021>

Jigsaw

<https://jigsawpshe.online>

Christopher Winter Project

<https://www.teachsre.co.uk/cwp-resources>

SEND focus

<https://www.sexeducationforum.org.uk/news/blog/2026-rshe-guidance-and-teaching-learners-send>

Masculinities

Male Allies UK

<https://www.maleallies.co.uk>

The Voice of the Boys report

<https://www.maleallies.co.uk/voice-of-the-boys-report/>

M-Path

<https://m-path.co.uk>

Boyz-2-Men

<https://boyz-2-men.org.uk>

Progressive Masculinities

<https://progressivemasculinity.co.uk>

Josh Sargent – (16 year old student online campaigner)

<https://www.joshsargent.co.uk>

SWGfL 'Incel Culture' Update (2025): <https://swgfl.org.uk/magazine/updated-rshe-guidance-aims-to-tackle-incele-culture/>

Brook

<https://www.brook.org.uk/education/teaching-about-misogyny-masculinity-and-stereotypes/>

End Violence Against Women Coalition Commentary (2025)

<https://www.endviolenceagainstwomen.org.uk/new-rshe-guidance-to-address-porn-misogyny-and-vawg/>

AI / Internet relevant

The Molly Rose foundation

<https://mollyrosefoundation.org>

NSPCC

<https://www.nspcc.org.uk/keeping-children-safe/online-safety/>

UK Safer Internet Centre

<https://www.iwf.org.uk/about-us/who-we-are/uk-safer-internet-centre/>

UK Council for Child Internet Safety

<https://www.gov.uk/government/groups/uk-council-for-child-internet-safety-ukccis>

SWGfL

<https://swgfl.org.uk>

Marriage, Sex and Relationships

Lovewise

<https://lovewise.org.uk>

Childnet

<https://www.childnet.com/resources/pshe-toolkit/myth-vs-reality/>

LGBTQ+

Stonewall

<https://www.stonewall.org.uk/shaping-policy/dont-repeat-history-protect-lgbtq-inclusive-education/guidance-for-inclusive-rhse-in-schools>

Pop n Olly

<https://www.popnolly.com>

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Section 10 – Key Vocabulary

Under the new guidance pupils are encouraged to be taught to use the proper terminology in RSHE, in order for them to be informed of what this is and to promote clear understanding, reduce stigma, and ensure they can communicate effectively. Correct terminology builds a foundation for understanding complex topics, helps children make informed choices, and provides them with the language to discuss their physical and mental health with confidence and respect. From defining terms accurately to fostering inclusivity, the words we choose and use in the PSHE classroom can have a profound impact on our students and their understanding.

Development of confident use of correct terminology can empower pupils, and help to reduce the risk of potential discomfort and division. Further, a key vocabulary list for parents/carers can help them to be aware of what vocabulary is used at school and reinforce its use at home. This may be particularly helpful for families whose first language is not English.

Schools may wish to compile a list of key vocabulary for circulation to parents/carers, or post it on their website. Advice on compiling a list is available to members of the PSHE Association, and Kingston, Richmond and Wandsworth Local Authorities may be able to help fund membership costs for schools in their area.- please let us know the details to include here